

Technical Note: *Rūpa*, *Guṇa*, *Svabhāva*, and *Dharma* in a State-Dynamic Unit

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Scope: This note clarifies the four inseparable aspects attributed to every unit (*ikai*) in Madhyasth Darshan: form (*rūpa*), property or relative power (*guṇa*), essential nature (*svabhāva*), and *dharma*. Its central question is whether a unit can consistently be understood as a process or activity at the fundamental level. The process-language below is an analytical reconstruction of the primary texts, not a claim that those texts explicitly adopt a modern school of process philosophy.

1. The interpretive problem

The four terms can initially look like a list of attributes attached to an otherwise passive thing. That reading becomes difficult once the same texts describe nature as countless activities, place effort, motion, and result inseparably in every activity, and state that force belongs to state while power belongs to motion. A purely static interpretation of the unit therefore misses the texts' insistence on continuous activeness. Yet a pure process interpretation can also mislead if it dissolves the unit into events or relations, because the unit remains a definite, bounded bearer with constitution, continuity, and its own "ness."

The more adequate interpretation is that a unit is a **bounded, state-dynamic activity-whole**. "State-dynamic" preserves the inseparability of state and motion; "activity-whole" preserves the unit as an identifiable bearer rather than a passing event. The four terms then name four irreducible aspects of this one active whole, not four separable components and not four successive stages.

Every unit is a bounded, state-dynamic activity-whole. As determinate configuration it is rūpa; as power in motion and mutual influence it is guṇa; as order-specific characteristic conduct it is svabhāva; and as abiding innateness and fulfillment it is dharma.

2. Four questions asked of one unit

Aspect	Question answered	Primary-text emphasis	Process-compatible reading
Form (<i>rūpa</i>)	What determinate configuration is present?	Shape, volume, density, boundary-framework and reflected image	The bounded configuration or presently maintained result of the unit's activity
Property (<i>guṇa</i>)	How does the unit's power operate?	Relative power; generative, degenerative, or mediative motion and effect in mutuality	The unit's operative power in motion and its definite influence when units come together
Essential nature (<i>svabhāva</i>)	What characteristic conduct or functional significance does that operation express?	Essentiality; usefulness of properties; conduct through which essentiality is expressed	The recurring, order-specific functional character displayed through the unit's powers
<i>Dharma</i>	What abiding continuity or fulfilment does the unit bear according to its order?	<i>Dhāraṇā</i> or innateness; existence, growth, hope to live, and happiness across the four orders	The deepest order-specific continuity and fulfilment evidenced through the unit's conduct

The table is analytical rather than sequential. A unit does not first acquire form, then activate property, then develop essential nature, and finally reach *dharma*. The four are simultaneous aspects of the same unit. Nor does “fundamental aspect” mean ontological independence: *svabhāva* depends on powers for its expression, but it cannot be reduced to a list of powers; *dharma* is evidenced through conduct, but it cannot be reduced to one episode of conduct.

3. The process basis: state, motion, and result

Madhyasth Darshan treats the unit as both a state and a motion. Force (*bal*) is identified on the side of state, power (*śakti*) on the side of motion, while state and motion remain inseparable. Every physical and chemical activity is correspondingly presented as the inseparable presence of effort, motion, and result (*śram–gati–pariṇām*). These are not three chronological moments. Effort names the active tendency already present, motion its dynamic expression, and result the determinate condition being attained or maintained (SB, pp. 58–62, 248–252).

One passage relates this triad directly to the four aspects: effort or force is present through *dharma* and *svabhāva*; motion through *svabhāva* and *guṇa*; and result through *rūpa*. This does not establish a one-to-one derivation, because *svabhāva* crosses both effort and motion. It does, however, make a static bundle-of-properties reading implausible. Form is connected to determinate result, property to motion, essential nature to the characteristic continuity of effort in motion, and *dharma* to what the unit bears through that continuity (SB, pp. 60–62). The resulting process-picture is therefore:

Activity-side	Ontological expression
Effort or force	The continuing capacity borne through <i>dharma</i> and expressed as <i>svabhāva</i>
Motion or power	The operative influence named by <i>guṇa</i> and characterised through <i>svabhāva</i>
Result	The determinate configuration evident as <i>rūpa</i> , together with the continuity achieved or maintained

4. Why *rūpa* is not an absolute effect

Form and property must not be separated as “absolute effect” and “relative effect.” *Rūpa* is not an effect in the same sense as *guṇa*. It is the real configuration by which the unit is bounded and individuated: shape, volume, and density. Its motion-path and constitution provide a framework within which the unit remains one definite unit. A developing atom can change in form as its constitution changes, so form is neither an immaterial essence nor an eternally immutable shape (MVD, pp. 42, 49–50; SB, pp. 55, 249–250).

Form is nevertheless relationally encountered. In mutual facing, the unit’s form is reflected or imaged to another unit, and its dimensions are measured only in comparison with another measure. Reflection does not create the form; it is the manner in which an already bounded unit becomes present across mutuality. The distinction is consequently between **unit-grounded configuration** and **relationally operative power**, not between absolute and relative effects.

The word “absolute” is especially unsuitable here because the texts reserve absolute truth for coexistence as nature saturated in *satta*. Form, properties, essential nature, and *dharma* together belong to the objective truth of units. A useful formulation is therefore:

Rūpa is objectively unit-grounded but relationally encountered; guṇa is unit-grounded as power and relationally actualised as effect.

5. *Guṇa*: relative power rather than a static quality

The primary definition calls *guṇa* relative power (*sāpekṣa śakti*) and also the effect that arises when more than one entity comes together. A later analysis identifies the force-bearing unit as *guṇī* and its power as *guṇa*: the bearer and the property are inseparable, while the property's operation is evident as motion, influence, and field of influence (MVD, p. 47; SB, pp. 248–252).

The three modes specify the direction of that operation:

Mode of <i>guṇa</i>	Definition	Direction of effect
<i>Sam</i>	Power assisting <i>srjan</i>	Generative, formative, or developmental
<i>Viṣam</i>	Power assisting <i>visarjan</i>	Degenerative, dissolutive, or declining
<i>Madhyastha</i>	Power assisting <i>vibhava</i>	Mediative, sustaining, balancing, and conserving

“Regenerative” is narrower than *sam*, because *srjan* need not restore a former state; “generative” is the safer general rendering. *Viṣam* is dissolutive rather than generative. *Madhyastha* does not mean inactivity or an average between two extremes. It names active regulation by which generative and degenerative movements remain balanced and a definite organisation is sustained (MVD, pp. 26, 49–50).

These modes are not moral categories. Formation and dissolution both participate in material and biological cycles. The triad names the directional character of power before any specifically biological, animal, or human evaluation of that power has been made.

6. *Svabhāva*: the functional character of *guṇa*

The primary text places two definitions together: essentiality or fundamental character (*maulikata*) is *svabhāva*, and the usefulness (*upayogitā*) of properties is *svabhāva* (MVD, p. 47). “Usefulness” cannot mean merely beneficial, agreeable, or useful to a human observer, because the same text includes devitalising and cruel essential natures. The term is better read here as **functional significance, operative relevance, or the kind of conduct in which the unit's powers become meaningful within an order.**

This explains why *svabhāva* is not merely another classification of *guṇa*. The generic classification of property remains *sam–viṣam–madhyastha* across all four orders, whereas the classification of essential nature changes with the order:

Order	Generic power-modes (<i>guṇa</i>)	Order-specific essential nature (<i>svabhāva</i>)
Material	Generative, degenerative, mediative	Integration–disintegration and their continuity
Biological or pranic	Generative, degenerative, mediative	Vitalising–devitalising
Animal	Generative, degenerative, mediative	Cruel–non-cruel
Knowledge or human	Generative, degenerative, mediative	Humane dispositions such as fortitude, courage, generosity, kindness, grace, and compassion, or their inhumane opposites

At the material level the distinction is thin: generative–degenerative motion and integration–disintegration conduct closely track one another. It becomes clearer in the higher orders. Generative activity alone does not tell whether a biological composition nourishes or debilitates a body, whether animal conduct causes or avoids suffering, or whether human conduct expresses cruelty or compassion. Those are further, order-specific determinations of what the powers amount to in conduct.

The texts therefore describe conduct as the activity through which essentiality is expressed and identify conduct itself with *svabhāva* (MVD, p. 76). Essential nature is unit-grounded as fundamental character but relation-disclosed in its expression. Recognition does not create it. A plant’s vitalising or devitalising character, an animal’s friendliness or opposition, and a human’s generosity or cruelty become evident only in definite mutualities, yet they are not arbitrary projections by an observer.

7. *Dharma*: the continuity or fulfilment borne by an order

The primary definition, *dhāraṇā hi dharma*, presents *dharma* as what is innately borne or maintained. In this technical use it does not initially mean religious affiliation, a statutory command, or an externally imposed moral duty. It names the deepest continuity and fulfilment characteristic of an order (MVD, p. 47).

The texts state the order-specific *dharma*s cumulatively:

Order	<i>Dharma</i>
Material	Existence

Order	<i>Dharma</i>
Biological or pranic	Existence and growth
Animal	Existence, growth, and hope to live
Knowledge or human	Existence, growth, hope to live, and happiness

The higher order does not lose the *dharma* of the lower. A biological unit remains existent while evidencing growth; an animal joint form evidences both and additionally the hope to live; the knowledge order bears the further possibility and requirement of happiness. The table does not imply that every composite organisation is indestructible. Existence belongs to the realities participating in composition, while particular compositions can form and disintegrate (MVD, pp. 49–51, 115; SB, p. 179).

Dharma is therefore not simply the long-term effect of *guṇa*. It supplies the order-defining continuity in relation to which conduct becomes fulfilled or unfulfilled. Property tells how power operates; essential nature tells what characteristic conduct that operation expresses; *dharma* tells what fundamental continuity or fulfilment the unit bears through such conduct.

8. Human relationships: where usefulness becomes explicitly normative

In human relationships, understanding adds a normative dimension that is not present in the same way in material mutuality. Understanding the relationship reveals its inherent value; the value makes appropriate conduct recognisable; humane *svabhāva* enables that value to be expressed; and fulfilment contributes to resolution and happiness. An action may be effective as *guṇa* while expressing an inhumane *svabhāva* and failing to fulfil human *dharma*. Manipulation can successfully influence another person, but causal effectiveness does not make the conduct just or mutually fulfilling.

It is consequently too narrow to define *svabhāva* universally as “what sustains a relationship.” Sustaining and balancing belong most directly to the mediative mode of *guṇa*, while human relationship-fulfilment additionally requires recognition of values, justice, and appropriate conduct. The human sequence can be stated as:

understanding of relationship → recognition of value → conduct expressing svabhāva → fulfilment contributing to human dharma

This is a human-order articulation, not a replacement for the broader definitions applying to material, biological, and animal nature.

9. Limits of the process interpretation

A process-oriented reading is consistent with the primary texts under four constraints.

First, “process” must mean persistent organised activity, not a momentary event. Units retain definite boundaries, constitutions, and identifiable continuity while remaining active.

Second, the four aspects must not be treated as chronological stages. Effort, motion, and result are inseparable in every activity; correspondingly, *rūpa*, *guṇa*, *svabhāva*, and *dharma* are co-present aspects of the unit.

Third, relational manifestation must not be confused with observer-construction. Form is reflected, property exerts influence, essential nature is recognised, and *dharma* is evaluated or fulfilled in mutuality; none is invented by the observer.

Fourth, the unit must not be reduced to its current relations. Madhyasth Darshan is process-compatible but not relation-only. The bearer (*guṇī*), its boundary, its constitution, its “ness,” and its order-specific *dharma* remain real. “Activity-whole” is therefore more faithful than saying that the unit is nothing but a process.

10. Compact formulation

Rūpa is how the unit’s activity is configured and bounded.

Guṇa is how its power operates and affects mutuality.

Svabhāva is what characteristic, order-specific conduct that operation expresses.

Dharma is what fundamental continuity or fulfilment the unit bears through that conduct.

The four can be compressed into one sentence without collapsing their differences:

A unit is a bounded activity-whole whose maintained configuration is rūpa, whose relative causal efficacy is guṇa, whose characteristic functional conduct is svabhāva, and whose abiding order-specific fulfilment is dharma.

References

Madhyasth Darshan primary texts

- **MVD** — Nagraj, A. [*Madhyasth Darshan — Co-existentialism*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: definitions of the four aspects (p. 47); form and the *sam-viṣam-madhyastha* distinction (pp. 49–50); order-specific *svabhāva* and *dharma* (pp. 50–51,

115); mediative regulation (p. 26); atomic constitution and change (p. 42); conduct as expression of essentiality (p. 76).

- **SB** — Nagraj, A. [*Samadhanatmak Bhautikvad \(Resolution Centred Materialism\)*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: effort–motion–result and state–motion (pp. 58–62); change of form and properties with development (p. 55); order-specific *dharma* (p. 179); force, power, bearer, property, form, reflection, influence, recognition, and evaluation (pp. 248–252).
- **JV** — Nagraj, A. [*Jeevan Vidya: An Introduction*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Consulted for the peepal-tree illustration of form, properties, essential nature, and *dharma* (p. 113).

Related study

- [*The Ontology of Coexistence*](#), especially §1.3, “The unit and its four aspects in mutuality.”